

Connecting to Wireless networks : When was the last time you heard about a laptop or a netbook which did not have the 'Wi-Fi' support? Unless you have been in love with computing for more than 8 years, your answer would be 'never'. We want each one of our devices to have a wireless support, for some even a desktop would be best if it had a Wi-Fi adapter. The more recent motherboards already have it. Most colleges across the country feel proud to announce that they provide Wi-Fi access to students. In such a case, it would be really necessary to know the 'how' part of a Wi-Fi connection.

Ubuntu is not very different from Windows 7 which happily lists down the available wireless networks when you click down the networking icon on the panel. You know how to connect to it already! Just click on the icon and you will be asked to enter the secret (we mean password). Enter it and you are ready to go. In case the network was open, the procedure is shorter, of course, skipping the password entry part.

Once again if you have disabled DHCP on Wi-Fi (and we suggest you to do so as it makes the work more complicated for someone who knows your password by trick or by luck) then you would have to change the IP address details. Once again, the same procedure: click network icon, then select 'Edit Connections' and select the entry you want to edit from the list on 'Wireless' tab. You know the rest.

In case your connection is one which is hidden, you can click on the network icon and click on the 'Connect to hidden network'. This should get you to the similar windows where you can enter the name of the network, the encryption options and the password, networking settings (DHCP or not, the IP addresses, DNS server addresses etc) and that would be good enough to get you going.

NOTE: One of the machines we installed Ubuntu 11.04 on kept showing the message "Wireless disabled by hardware switch" under the networking icon menu on the panel. In case you get the same, the following command should work for you:

- `sudo rfkill unblock all`

Changing other settings

There are a lot of other settings which can or need to be changed for getting your computer run the way your desires direct it to. Linux since very long has suffered the lack of a Windows style Control Panel. There has been openSuSE which uses Yast as the control panel. In Ubuntu and many other